

One Holy Catholic Apostolic Church

doc-one-holy-catholic-apostolic-church
Ecclesiology · Nature of the Church · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth broad
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

The Church is one, holy, catholic, and apostolic, as the Nicene Creed confesses.

In plain language

Looking only at the original-language words, the four labels in the stem stand on different footings. Oneness is the strongest. Ephesians 4:4-6 hammers the number 'one' (εἷς, mia, hen) in masculine, feminine, and neuter forms across body, Spirit, hope, Lord, faith, baptism, and God, and Ephesians 4:3 uses a rare word for oneness (ἐνότης, henotes) that appears only twice in the whole New Testament, both times right here. Holiness is dense and spread across the canon. The word for 'holy' (ἅγιος, hagios) occurs over two hundred times, and Ephesians 2:19 calls the believers themselves 'the holy ones' or 'the saints' (τῶν ἁγίων, ton hagion) while Ephesians 2:21 says the joined structure grows into 'a holy temple' (ναὸν ἅγιον, naon hagion). The apostolic label is plain in two ways. Ephesians 2:20 says believers are built on the 'foundation of the apostles' (θεμελίῳ τῶν ἀποστόλων, themelio ton apostolon) and prophets with Christ as the cornerstone, and Acts 2:42 shows the first believers devoting themselves to the 'teaching of the apostles' (διδασκίᾳ τῶν ἀποστόλων, didache ton apostolon). Here the words leave room. A foundation in these texts is laid once and is Christ, as 1 Corinthians 3 puts it, so the words clearly support apostolic foundation and apostolic doctrine, but they do not by themselves decide whether 'apostolic' also means a continuing office handed down, which is where readers diverge. The one word with no match at all is the term behind 'catholic', meaning 'universal' or 'whole' (καθολικός, katholikos). Searching the Greek New Testament directly, that word never appears. The nearest word means 'at all' (καθόλου, katholou) and shows up once in a flat denial. Yet the idea is still there, because Ephesians speaks of 'one body' (ἐν σῶμα, hen soma) and piles up 'all' and 'of all' (πᾶς, πάντων, pas, panton). The word for 'church' or 'assembly' (ἐκκλησία, ekklesia) is also used far more often for single local gatherings than for one worldwide body, so the universal sense is real but is carried by phrases rather than by one matching word. The honest conclusion from the words alone is that the assembled believers are pictured as one, holy, and apostolically founded, and as a single whole including all the called, which is the substance the stem describes, even though the four-mark list and two of its labels are later than the text.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0040	ἅγιος	hagios	holy	209
G0204	ἀκρογωνιαίος	akrogoniaios	cornerstone	2
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	77
G0908	βάπτισμα	baptisma	baptism	
G1322	διδασκίᾳ	didache	teaching	28
G1515	εἰρήνης	eirēnē	peace	
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	247

G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	109
G1680	ἐλπίς	elpis	hope	
G1775	ἐνότης	henotes	unity	2
G2026	ἐποικοδομέω	epoikodomeo	to build up/upon	5
G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	14
G2527	καθόλου	katholou	at all	
G2732	κατοικητήριον	katoiketerion	dwelling place	2
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	14
G3485	ναός	naos	temple	34
G3609	οἰκεῖοι	oikeios	of one's household	
G3619	οικοδομή	oikodomē	building	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	960
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	100

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Querying the tagged Greek New Testament, the four attributes rest on uneven lexical footing. ONE is explicit and emphatic: Ephesians 4:4-6 stacks the cardinal numeral 'one' (εἷς, μία, ἓν, transliterated heis, mia, hen, Strong's G1520, with 247 tagged occurrences) across body, Spirit, hope, Lord, faith, baptism, and God, and Ephesians 4:3 and 4:13 carry the rare noun 'oneness' or 'unity' (ἐνότης, henotes, Strong's G1775), which occurs only twice in the canon and both times in this one chapter. HOLY is dense and pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible): the word 'holy' (ἅγιος, hagios, Strong's G0040, with 209 occurrences) names the believers themselves as 'the holy ones' or 'the saints' (τῶν ἁγίων, ton hagian) in Ephesians 2:19 and the corporate building as 'a holy temple' (ναὸν ἅγιον, naon hagian) in Ephesians 2:21. APOSTOLIC is anchored by the phrase 'on the foundation of the apostles' (ἐπὶ τῷ θεμελίῳ τῶν ἀποστόλων, epi to themelio ton apostolon) in Ephesians 2:20 and 'the teaching of the apostles' (τῇ διδασκῇ τῶν ἀποστόλων, te didache ton apostolon) in Acts 2:42, but the genitive (the 'of-X' grammatical form) and the once-laid foundation grammar of 1 Corinthians 3:10-11 support an apostolic-foundation or apostolic-doctrine sense and do not by themselves encode transmitted office. CATHOLIC has no lexeme (no matching word) at all: the Greek word for universal (καθολικός, katholikos) never occurs in the New Testament, so the universality is carried only conceptually by the phrase 'one body' (ἐν σῶμα, hen soma) and the 'all, of all' (πᾶς, πάντων, pas, panton) series. Three marks rest on explicit words and the fourth on a defensible conceptual reading, so the substance affirms while the formal four-mark frame is creedally preloaded.

Scripture

Eph.4.4 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 ἐν, G4983 σῶμα, G1680 ἐλπίς

Force. 'One body and one Spirit' (ἐν σῶμα καὶ ἐν πνεῦμα, hen soma kai hen pneuma), paired with the single calling and the one hope. The neuter cardinal 'one' (ἐν, hen) is repeated to assert the numerical oneness of the body of believers. The noun 'body' (σῶμα, soma, Strong's G4983, with 100 occurrences) names that one body, which is the lexical seat (the word-level basis) of both the oneness mark and the conceptual universality the creedal word 'catholic' (meaning universal) names.

Eph.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G0908 βάπτισμα

Force. 'One Lord, one faith, one baptism' (εἷς κύριος, μία πίστις, ἓν βάπτισμα, heis kyrios, mia pistis, hen baptisma). The triple cardinal numeral 'one' in masculine, feminine, and neuter agreement underlines a single confessional and sacramental ground for the one church. The numeral 'one' (Strong's G1520) occurs 247 times across the canon, so the sense is stable and not in doubt.

Eph.4.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G3956 πάντων

Force. 'One God and Father of all' (εἷς θεὸς καὶ πατὴρ πάντων, heis theos kai pater panton), with 'who is over all and through all and in all' (ὁ ἐπὶ πάντων καὶ διὰ πάντων καὶ ἐν πᾶσιν, ho epi panton kai dia panton kai en pasin). The pairing of the cardinal 'one' (εἷς, heis) with the universalizing word 'all' (πᾶς, pas, Strong's G3956, with 960 occurrences) supplies the conceptual basis for a whole or universal church, which is the substance the creedal word 'catholic' (universal) names, though no single Greek word 'universal' (καθολικός, katholikos) is used.

Eph.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1775 ἐνότης, G1515 εἰρήνης

Force. 'Eager to keep the oneness of the Spirit' (σπουδάζοντες τηρεῖν τὴν ἐνότητα τοῦ πνεύματος, spoudazontes terein ten henoteta tou pneumatos). The noun 'oneness' or 'unity' (ἐνότης, henotes, Strong's G1775) occurs only twice in the entire New Testament, here and at Ephesians 4:13, both inside this one paragraph, so oneness is named as an explicit attribute of the church but the explicit noun does not recur elsewhere in the canon.

Eph.2.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0040 ἁγίων, G3609 οἰκεῖοι

Force. 'You are no longer strangers and sojourners, but you are fellow citizens with the saints (the holy ones) and members of God's household' (οὐκέτι ἐστὲ ξένοι καὶ πάροικοι, ἀλλὰ ἐστὲ συμπολίται τῶν ἁγίων καὶ οἰκεῖοι τοῦ θεοῦ, ouketi este xenoi kai paroikoi, alla este sympolitai ton hagion kai oikeioi tou theou). The believers themselves are named 'the holy ones' (τῶν ἁγίων, ton hagion), the substantive use (the use as a noun) of 'holy' (ἅγιος, hagios, Strong's G0040, with 209 occurrences), which grounds the holiness mark in the people, not just in the temple image of the next verses.

Eph.2.20 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0652 ἀποστόλων, G2310 θεμελίω, G0204 ἀκρογωνιαίου

Force. 'Built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone' (ἐποικοδομηθέντες ἐπὶ τῷ θεμελίῳ τῶν ἀποστόλων καὶ προφητῶν, ὄντος ἀκρογωνιαίου αὐτοῦ Χριστοῦ Ἰησοῦ, epikodomethentes epi to themelio ton apostolon kai propheton, ontos akrogoniaiou autou Christou Iesou). The construction lexically anchors the apostolic mark. The genitive (the 'of-X' grammatical form) 'of the apostles' (τῶν ἀποστόλων, ton apostolon) is ambiguous between the foundation laid by the apostles and the foundation consisting of the apostles, and the cornerstone word (ἀκρογωνιάς, akrogoniaios, Strong's G0204, only here and 1 Peter 2:6) is consistently Christ, not the apostles.

Eph.2.21 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3485 ναὸν, G0040 ἅγιον, G3956 πᾶσα

Force. 'The whole structure being joined together grows into a holy temple' (πᾶσα οἰκοδομὴ συναρμολογουμένη αὖξαι εἰς ναὸν ἅγιον, pasa oikodome synarmologoumene auxai eis naon hagion). The adjective 'holy' (ἅγιος, hagios) applied to the corporate building directly anchors the holiness mark, and 'whole' or 'every' (πᾶσα, pasa) marks the structure as a single growing whole, joining the holiness and universality senses in one clause.

Eph.2.22 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2732 κατοικητήριον

Force. 'In whom you also are being built together into a dwelling place of God in the Spirit' (ἐν ᾧ καὶ ὑμεῖς συνοικοδομεῖσθε εἰς κατοικητήριον τοῦ θεοῦ ἐν πνεύματι, en ho kai hymeis synoikodomeisthe eis katoiketerion tou theou en pneumati). The 'together' prefix (συν, syn) and the singular dwelling 'dwelling place' (κατοικητήριον, katoiketerion, Strong's G2732, only twice in the canon) reinforce the corporate oneness and consecration of the assembled believers.

Acts.2.42 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1322 διδαχῇ, G2842 κοινωνία, G0652 ἀποστόλων

Force. 'They were devoting themselves to the teaching of the apostles and to the fellowship' (ἦσαν δὲ προσκαρτεροῦντες τῇ διδαχῇ τῶν ἀποστόλων καὶ τῇ κοινωνίᾳ, esan de proskarterountes te didache ton apostolon kai te koinonia). The genitive (the 'of-X' grammatical form) 'of the apostles' (τῶν ἀποστόλων, ton apostolon) binds the community to apostolic instruction, 'teaching' (διδαχῇ, didache, Strong's G1322), supplying narrative attestation of the apostolic mark in its doctrine sense alongside the foundation image of Ephesians 2:20.

1Cor.3.11 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιον

Force. 'No one can lay another foundation than the one already laid, which is Jesus Christ' (θεμέλιον γὰρ ἄλλον οὐδεὶς δύναται θεῖναι παρὰ τὸν κείμενον, ὅς ἐστιν Ἰησοῦς Χριστός, themelion gar allon oudeis dynatai theinai para ton keimenon, hos estin Iesous Christos). With 1 Corinthians 3:10, where Paul laid the foundation once and another builds on it, the word 'foundation' (θεμέλιος, themelios) is grammatically a once-laid base. This controls the apostolic mark toward foundation and away from a continuously transmitted office, since a foundation by definition is not re-laid.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.2.20	Isa.28.16	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Eph.4.11	tsk	1
Eph.2.21	Eph.4.13	tsk	1
Eph.4.4	Eph.4.1	tsk	1
Eph.4.6	Eph.1.21	tsk	1
Eph.2.21	Ps.93.5	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Nicene-mark-catholic · addressed

The creedal mark 'catholic' translates 'universal' or 'whole' (καθολικός, katholikos), but direct query of the tagged Greek New Testament returns zero occurrences of that word. The only related form is 'at all' (καθόλου, katholou, Strong's G2527), which appears once at Acts 4:18 inside a prohibition and means 'not at all', not 'universal'. So the term behind 'catholic' is post-canonical (a word that came after the New Testament was finished). The concept of a single universal body is carried lexically (at the word level) by 'one body' (ἐν σῶμα, hen soma) at Ephesians 4:4 and the 'all, of all' (πᾶς, πάντων, pas, panton) series at Ephesians 4:6, so the substance is attested even though the word is not. The verdict affirms the concept, not the word.

Eph.2.20 · addressed

The genitive (the 'of-X' grammatical form) 'of the apostles and prophets' (τῶν ἀποστόλων καὶ προφητῶν, ton apostolon kai propheton) can be read as the foundation laid by apostles and prophets or as the foundation that consists of them. Either reading keeps the apostolic mark intact, since both make the apostolic witness foundational. The further question of apostolic foundation versus transmitted apostolic succession is not settled by the words here. The once-laid foundation grammar of 1 Corinthians 3:10-11 and the fixed twelve foundations of Revelation 21:14 lean the vocabulary toward a single non-repeating foundation rather than an ongoing office, so the verdict affirms the foundation and doctrine sense and leaves the succession question lexically (at the word level) underdetermined.

G1577-ekklesia-scope · addressed

The noun 'assembly' or 'church' (ἐκκλησία, ekklesia, Strong's G1577) occurs 109 times and is used overwhelmingly for individual local assemblies, the churches of Acts 14:23, 15:41, 16:5 and the city congregations of Paul, while Matthew 16:18 and the Ephesians whole-body texts use the singular universal sense. The word itself does not rank the local and universal patterns. This is why the universality mark, while conceptually present, is not forced by the vocabulary alone, and contributes to the medium rather than high confidence.

Concordance traversed

G1520, G1775, G0040, G0652, G2310, G0204, G3485, G1322, G2842, G3956, G4983, G1577, G2026, G2732, G3619, G2527

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Direct query of the ingested apparatus (the catalog of textual variants) shows VariantUnit nodes exist only for 3 John, 116 units, so the cited Ephesians and Acts texts lie entirely outside the open-cbqm published sample and no CBQM (a computer-assisted method for tracing variant relationships) data applies. The editions field on the tagged tokens shows the cardinal numerals and the apostolic and holy words are present across NA28, SBL, WH, Treg, TR, and Byz alike (the major published Greek New Testament editions). The editorial marks the bundle flags at Ephesians 2:19 ('you are', ἐστὲ, este), 2:20 (word order of 'Christ Jesus', Χριστοῦ Ἰησοῦ, Christou Iesou), 2:21 ('whole' or 'every', πᾶσα, pasa), and 4:6 ('in all', ἐν πᾶσιν, en pasin) touch wording but none alter the cardinal numerals or the apostolic and holy words that carry the verdict, so the verdict is variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. apostolic_foundation, apostolic_succession, covenant_theology, dispensationalism

analogia scripturae invoked

apostolic_foundation_doctrine: affirms · Reads 'on the foundation of the apostles' (ἐπὶ τῷ θεμελίῳ τῶν ἀποστόλων, epi to themelio ton apostolon) at Ephesians 2:20 and 'the teaching of the apostles' (τῇ διδασκαλίᾳ τῶν ἀποστόλων, te didache ton apostolon) at Acts 2:42 as the church resting on the apostles' once-given teaching and witness. The foundation grammar of 1 Corinthians 3:10-11, where the foundation is laid once and is Christ, and the fixed twelve foundations of Revelation 21:14 fit this reading. On this lens 'apostolic' means grounded in apostolic doctrine, and all four marks stand on the actual words.

apostolic_succession_office: disputed · Reads 'apostolicity' as a transmitted office continuing the apostles' authority. At the word level, 'apostle' or 'sent one' (ἀπόστολος, apostolos, Strong's G0652, with 77 occurrences) does carry a sent-one sense that extends beyond the Twelve, naming Paul, Barnabas at Acts 14:14, and others, which keeps an office reading available. But the anchor texts speak of a foundation, not a succession, and the words for laying a foundation describe a non-repeating act, so this lens is not foreclosed yet is not demanded by the cited vocabulary. The succession claim is the part of the proposition the words underdetermine.

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the one body, one Spirit, one Lord series as one covenant people across the testaments, so the oneness and holiness marks are continuous attributes of the gathered church and the saints (the holy ones) of Ephesians 2:19 stand in continuity with the holy ones of the older Scriptures.

dispensationalism: affirms · Treats 'one body' (ἐν σῶμα, hen soma) and the temple imagery of Ephesians 2:21 as the present-age body distinct from national Israel, yet still affirms that this body is one, holy, and apostolically founded on the same words, so the marks themselves are not in dispute under this lens. The only divergence is the referent and timing of the one body, not whether it is one, holy, and apostolic.

The covenant and dispensational frameworks converge on the four marks because the verdict rests on cardinal numerals and explicit words rather than on covenantal sequencing. The live divergence is internal to the apostolic mark, between an apostolic foundation and doctrine reading that the vocabulary supports and an apostolic succession reading that the vocabulary permits but does not require.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The gathered company of believers is described in Scripture as a single body, set apart as holy, encompassing all the called, and founded on the teaching of the apostles.

The stem cites the Nicene Creed and its four marks one, holy, catholic, apostolic by name, which preloads a formal four-mark verdict frame the canon does not itself enumerate as a list. The lexical (word-level) test was run on the neutralized form. Three marks rest on explicit New Testament words: 'oneness' (ἐνότης, henotes) and the 'one' (εἷς, heis) series for oneness, 'holy' (ἅγιος, hagios) for holiness including the believers as 'the holy ones' (τῶν ἁγίων, ton hagion), and 'apostle' (ἀπόστολος, apostolos) with 'foundation' (θεμέλιος, themelios) for apostolicity. The fourth mark 'catholic' has no New Testament word 'universal' (καθολικός, katholikos), the only related word being 'at all' (καθόλου, katholou) meaning 'at all', and is affirmed only at the conceptual level through 'one body' (ἐν σῶμα, hen soma) and the 'all' (πᾶς, pas) series. The apostolic mark is itself split between a foundation and doctrine sense the words support and a succession sense the words permit but do not force, which is why confidence is medium rather than high. The affirms value is unchanged from the prior file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.4.4
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.4.5
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1775
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0040
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0652
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2527
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.2.20
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.2.21
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.2.20

License audit

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Flags

ecm-shadow